

Alexus Adkins

Dr. Clapp-Itnyre

English L391

April 26, 2024

Friendships in *We Were Liars* and *The Hate U Give* (topic 4)

In *We Were Liars* by E. Lockhart, the protagonist, Cadence Sinclair Easton, is a teenage girl who is a member of the wealthy Sinclair family. Through the point of view provided by Cadence, readers see how her friendships help to reveal the imperfections in the Sinclair family. In *The Hate U Give*, the protagonist, Starr Carter, is a Black teenage girl who lives in the predominantly Black neighborhood of Garden Heights, while attending the predominantly white school, Williamson Prep. Through the lens of Starr's eyes, readers see how her friendships and the events surrounding them force her to speak out about the racism and injustice perpetrated by people at Williamson and faced by people in Garden Heights. In Young Adult Literature, friendship is a common theme—as characters are teenagers experiencing complex emotions and they are easier to process when connected to others. In this paper, I will discuss how the protagonists in *We Were Liars* and *The Hate U Give* are impacted by their friendships.

In *We Were Liars*, friendship is significant to this novel because the Liars are the only people Cadence feels a real connection with. The plot revolves around Cadence and her friend/crush, Gat, and her cousins, Johnny and Mirren. She is connected to the Liars through their mothers—her mother is a sister to Johnny and Mirren's, while Gat's uncle dates Johnny's mother. Her desire to be with the Liars is displayed throughout the entire novel. The most prominent example of this being when the Liars decide to burn the grandfather's house down

because they are worried that it could be Gat's last summer with the family, due to the sister's fighting. In the discussions, Emily Marks reasoned the Liars decision to, "The aunts were constantly fighting, and Granddad was being hateful towards Gat and his race. The Liars were afraid they wouldn't have another summer, all four together again if they didn't stop the adults" (*We Were Liars* Discussion #2, L391 Spring 2024). While the novel includes quotes like, "Gat and I talked to Mirren and Johnny. Convinced them to take action. We told each other over and over: do what you are afraid to do...we told each other we were right" (Lockhart 200), that makes audiences assume that the plan was driven by the romantic feeling share between Cadence and Gat, it does not account for Johnny and Mirren's acceptance. Cadence's cousins also knew that Gat was the only one not connected by blood and Johnny mentions, "if my mom left Ed, Gat wouldn't be connected to our family anymore" (Lockhart 196). Since Johnny and Mirren were willing to go along with the plan, it shows that the Liars, caring more about their friendships than the family drama, were willing to do anything to stay together.

In contrast, friendship is important to Starr from *The Hate U Give* because it is one of the things that anchor her within her communities at Garden Heights, a neighborhood that is lower-class and considered dangerous, and Williamson Prep, a school for upper-class students. In Garden Heights, Starr's most important friendships are with Khalil and Natasha, who are both killed in front of her before the story can truly begin. Khalil's death is the catalyst to the entire story, as it is what leads Starr's journey throughout the novel while Natasha's death provided Starr with her first glimpse of grief. These friends offered Starr a different perspective as they connected Garden Heights to her childhood and truly made her feel like part of a community. Through her friendships with Khalil and Natasha, Starr experienced childhood joy and nostalgia in her community, such as eating Freeze Cups when someone won a game (Thomas 59), as well

as the most profound pain. These friendships continue Starr beyond their deaths because she has had to look at her life and community through the lens of violence and racism. After Khalil and Natasha had both died, that left Starr with Kenya. Kenya provided a different type of friendship than Khalil and Natasha because Starr will always be connected to Kenya because they share a brother, Seven. Kenya impacts Starr directly in her struggle to come forward by pushing her to speak up after finding out Starr was the witness in Khalil's death because they wanted justice and lead to Starr's creation of the Tumblr page for Khalil.

At Williamson Prep, Starr's closest friends are Maya, an Asian girl, and Hailey, a white girl. While Maya is shown to be supportive of Starr, Hailey is more of a hindrance. Maya provided crucial support for Starr after the interview with One Fifteen's father aired and Hailey made comments showing sympathy for One Fifteen. After Hailey left, Maya supported Starr by making it clear that Hailey's reasons for unfollowing her were racist, despite Hailey's denial. She also supported Starr here by creating a "minority alliance" (Thomas 251), that was put into action when Maya supported Starr after Hailey found out that Starr lied about not knowing Khalil.

Hailey being a hindrance for Starr is present throughout the entire novel, but it isn't something Starr notices immediately. The first time Starr really acknowledges Hailey's racism for what it is was when Hailey said, "Hustle! Pretend the ball is some fried chicken. Bet you'll stay on it then" (Thomas 111). A classmate, Summer Hendershot, adds onto this saying, "I felt that this was an accurate depiction of a stereotype based on what I have seen on social media and what stereotypes I have heard of in my life" (*The Hate U Give* Discussion #1 L391, Spring 2024). This was a hindrance to Starr because she thought Hailey was someone she could trust,

but instead she was someone who would make racial comments about Starr and the members of her community.

Cadence has a more idealized version of her friendships, compared to Starr. In Cadence's friendship, she seems to have this mindset where she thinks she needs them. An example of this, prior to their deaths, is how she viewed Gat to be hers despite him having a girlfriend, while after their deaths, this can be seen in how she projects a boyfriend onto Mirren's "ghost." In the novel, there is a time when Cadence remarks, "I do not want to be separated from them. Ever" (Lockhart 154). Quotes like this show how Cadence uses her friends as a safety net. An element of them being her safety net is that she was willing to do anything for them. This willingness to do anything for them is what leads Cadence to look at the fire as, "We saved the family. They started over" (Lockhart 202), instead of realizing that the fire had killed her friends. The biggest way Cadence's idealization of them is shown is when the plot twist reveals that they have died. In this moment, it becomes clear to readers that her friends did not ignore her after her accident. In fact, Cadence used their memory to help her work through her memory loss and grief. A classmate, Cadence Wright, wrote something eye-catching. She wrote, "It is not only Cadence's memory, but her headaches that make her unreliable" (*We Were Liars* Discussion #1 L391, Spring 2024). This was eye-catching as it shows the guilt that followed Cadence's idealization of her friends, as it is what led them to cause the fire. She thought she couldn't live without them in her life, but she could.

For Starr, her friendships were real, with some bordering on problematic. This is because Starr experience's identity issues in her story and part of this is acknowledging the problems in her friendships. Two of Starr's friendships that had issues throughout the novel were with Hailey and Kenya. In her friendship with Hailey, Starr really begins to realize Hailey's racism after

Khalil's death. The first sign of this happens before the novel's events when Starr narrates about when Hailey unfollowed her on Tumblr after she reposted a photo of Emmett Till. When discussing Hailey's response, Starr says, "Hailey texted me immediately after, freaking out. I thought it was because she couldn't believe someone would do that to a kid. No. She couldn't believe I would reblog such an awful picture" (Thomas 77). This was the first sign of Hailey's racism. After Khalil is murdered, Starr starts to become more aware of Hailey's racism, before it comes to a head in the school hallway after Hailey makes comments about Khalil's death. In these comments, the one that set Starr off was when Hailey said, "the cop probably did everyone a favor. One less drug dealer on the—" (Thomas 341). This comment led to a fight between the girls that got Starr suspended from school. Eventually, Hailey apologized, but not for the reasons Starr hoped for. After Hailey chose to "apologize" because Starr was upset with her, Starr knew that it was officially time to cut her off, deleting her number from her phone.

Starr's friendship with Kenya got a different ending. One of the biggest hiccups come when Kenya finds out Starr is the witness. Kenya is not happy with Starr for keeping the news that she was the witness in Khalil's death a secret and confronted Starr about her secrecy. In this confrontation, Kenya tells Starr that "the Khalil I know would've jumped on TV in a hot second and told everybody what happened that night if it meant defending you. And you can't do the same for him" (Thomas 198). This moment served as a catalyst for Starr as she knew Kenya was right in her assessment. After this, Starr started slowly making progress towards revealing that she was the witness, starting with her creation of a Tumblr page about Khalil's life. In the end, Starr reveals herself as the witness and tries to get justice for Khalil and she makes up with Kenya, reaffirming their friendship outside of their shared half-brother.

It is important to note that the complications between Hailey and Kenya, that add to the realism in her friendships, are largely a result of Starr trying to separate who she is in Garden Heights from who she is at Williamson Prep. A classmate, Sophia Vincent, discusses this, saying “As Starr leaves the world of Garden Heights and enters Williamson, she has to alter her personality to fit the new setting. Starr describes this as ‘flipping the switch’ on her personality so that she can fit in” (*The Hate U Give* Discussion #1 L391, Spring 2024). This perfectly describes the code switching that Starr does when she is around her Williamson friends, as she does not think they will want to be around her if she acts like herself. Starr is not entirely wrong about this, as her friends like Hailey did not like it when they got glimpses of the real Starr, while Chris encouraged Starr to be herself.

In addition, the friendships displayed in *We Were Liars* and *The Hate U Give* will always be different due to cultural differences between Cadence and Starr. The cultural difference between Cadence and Starr is most prevalent in their communities. While Cadence is upper-class, Starr lives in a lower-class region. This is something called out in both novels. In *We Were Liars*, this is expressed best through Gat. While Johnny and Mirren are related to Cadence and come from the same background, Gat is considered an outsider due to his Indian descent and his working-class life. This can be seen through the story of the youngest princess and the mouse. In this story, it says, “He is unnatural. An animal masquerading as a person” (Lockhart 117). This relates to the Liars because Cadence is viewed as the young princess and Gat is viewed similarly as the mouse while in Beechwood, due to his differences.

In *The Hate U Give*, this is best expressed through Starr’s relationship with Chris. A good example of these cultural differences was when they discussed stereotypes in the car with Seven and DeVante. In this discussion, the cultural differences can be seen through Starr’s statement of

“white people always wanna split up, and when they do something bad happens” and Chris’ questioning of “Why do some black people give their kids odd names? I mean, look at you guys’ names. They’re not normal” (Thomas 400). In a review for *The Hate U Give*, the reviewer mentions these cultural differences. He states, “Representation is key and Angie Thomas’ *The Hate U Give* finally unlocks the door barred shut by popular literature” (Omar, “Review of *The Hate U Give*”). This brought up the idea that if these novels became one: Cadence, Johnny, and Mirren would be like Starr’s Williamson friends, while Gat would be closer to her Garden Heights friends with Cadence’s grandfather and Starr’s father being two sides of the same coin. This is worth mentioning as class and race are the colliding themes found in both novels.

In conclusion, *The Hate U Give* conveys the importance and impact of friendship better because *The Hate U Give* features friendships that are complex, while Cadence’s are lackluster. In Garden Heights, she had Kenya, who she could be herself around, but still felt a bit out of place because of their shared brother. While in Williamson Prep, she had Hailey, who she censored herself around to prevent being seen as too “Black.” In the end, Starr talked things out or dropped the “friends” who made her feel like she had to be unauthentic to herself and was able to blend her Garden Heights friends with her Williamson friends. Cadence, on the other hand, had friendships that felt one-dimensional. In a review for *We Were Liars*, the reviewer mentions this, saying, “The ‘Liars’ themselves are uninteresting. Slice of life stories, which is what this story is in the beginning, can be fascinating if done right. However, the characters are uninteresting and uninspired. I don’t care what they do on a day-to-day basis. Who are they? What am I supposed to be shown about them” (Liz, “Review of *We Were Liars*”). This is a valid point to make as it is difficult to understand what exactly made the Liars so dependent on each other. In essence, Starr and her friends feel like they could have been real people, Cadence and

her friends do not. Despite Cadence's idealized view of her friends and Starr's realistic view, these protagonists can connect through their shared grief of their friends. In both novels, we see how the characters deal with their grief and how it affects the people around them. While Cadence has an idealized version of her friends, they were still dear to her and will leave an impact on her forever, similarly to how Natasha and Khalil's deaths will always affect Starr.

Works Cited

Hendershot, Summer. Student Discussion #1 on *The Hate U Give*. For English L391, Indiana University East, Spring 2024.

Liz. "Review of *We Were Liars*". Goodreads. January 3, 2014.

Lockhart, E. *We Were Liars*. Delacorte Press, 2014.

Marks, Emily. Student Discussion #2 on *We Were Liars*. For English L391, Indiana University East, Spring 2024.

Omar, Rakeem. "Review of *The Hate U Give*." Medium. May 17, 2017.

Thomas, Angie. *The Hate U Give*. HarperCollins, 2017.

Vincent, Sophia. Student Discussion #1 on *The Hate U Give*. For English L391, Indiana University East, Spring 2024.

Wright, Cadence. Student Discussion #1 on *We Were Liars*. For English L391, Indiana University East Spring 2024.